Drugs in Medicine

Exam code: 0610 & 0970

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Written by: Phil
Reviewed by: Lára Marie McIvor
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What is a drug?

Drug definition

- A drug is **any substance taken into the body that modifies or affects chemical reactions in the body**
- Some drugs are medicinal drugs that are used to treat the symptoms or causes of a disease - for example, **antibiotics**
  - The **liver** is the primary site for drug metabolism

Did this video help you? Yes No

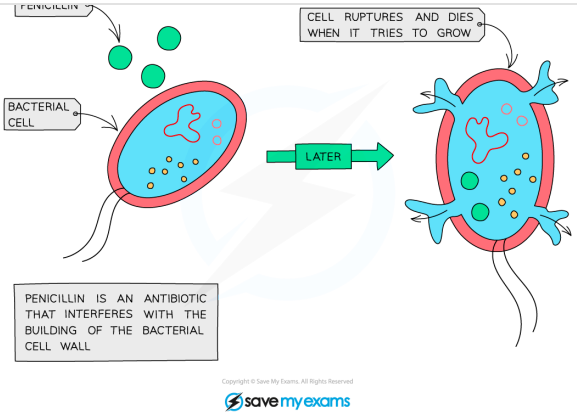
Help me understand

Antibiotics

What are antibiotics?

- Antibiotics are **chemical substances** made by certain **fungi or bacteria** that affect the working of bacterial cells, either by **disrupting their structure or function** or by **preventing them from reproducing.**
- Antibiotics are **effective against bacteria but not against viruses.**
- Antibiotics target processes and structures that are specific to bacterial (prokaryotic) cells; as such they do not generally harm animal cells.

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it



How antibiotics work

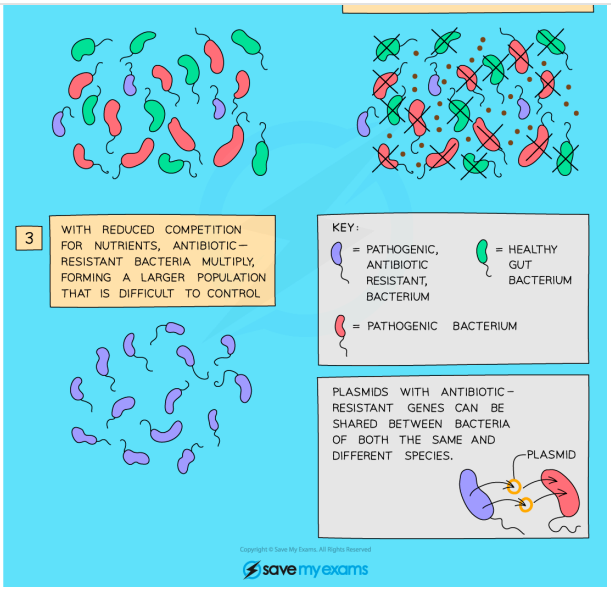
Antibiotic resistance & use: extended

- Commonly prescribed antibiotics are becoming **less effective** due to a number of reasons:
  - **overuse** and being prescribed when not really necessary
  - patients **failing to complete the fully prescribed course** by a doctor
  - large scale **use of antibiotics in farming** to prevent disease when livestock are kept in close quarters, even when animals are not actually sick
- This has led to the effectiveness of antibiotics being reduced, and the incidence of antibiotic resistance increasing
- These bacteria are commonly known as superbugs and the most common is **MRSA**

How to prevent antibiotic resistance

- Ways individuals can help **prevent** the incidence of antibiotic resistance increasing include:
  - only taking antibiotics when **absolutely essential**
  - when prescribed a course of antibiotics, **ensure that the entire course is completed** even if you feel better after a few days

Mechanism of antibiotic resistance diagram



Antibiotic resistance

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